AREA MANAGER ESSENTIALS

Area Manager Essentials — Day 5: Run Area Reviews That Sustain Improvement

Study guide · Self-study

Day 5: Run Area Reviews That Sustain Improvement

How to Use This Guide

This guide is your material for Day 5, the last unit of Area Manager Essentials. You work through it alone. Take about 45 minutes, pen in hand. Write your answers to every "What Would You Say?" exercise before you look at the model answers at the end. The models are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

This unit builds on the four days before it. You already separate area accountability from running one unit, compare results with context, coach managers on their selling behavior, and tell a local problem from an area-wide one. Today you put all of it into one habit: the area sales review. You will learn to summarize results, explain customer-facing risks, report progress on what you promised, and ask for the decisions only senior leaders can make. You will keep unit managers in charge of execution, where they belong.

By the end you will have produced two things yourself: an area review summary and a 30-day improvement plan with measures, owners, support requests, and review dates. Keep both. You will need them for the final assessment.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: what a concise area sales review contains, what belongs in an upward summary versus a unit manager's execution plan, and why unexplained silence reads to clients and senior leaders as uncertainty.

Attitude: you run reviews to sustain improvement, not to perform activity. You report what is true, you recommend what you would do, and you leave execution with the manager who owns it.

Skill: produce an area review summary and a 30-day improvement plan with measures, owners, support requests, and review dates, in a form a senior leader can act on in minutes.

Upskill: lead a review conversation in which a senior leader makes a real decision and your unit managers leave knowing exactly what they own and when they will report back.

The Area Review: What It Is For

A review is not a report card and not a meeting where you retell every conversation of the month. It is a decision instrument. Senior leaders read it to answer three questions: are we on track, what is at risk on the customer side, and what do you need from me? If your review does not help them answer those three, it is too long or too vague.

Most reviews fail in one of two ways. Some drown in detail: every unit's numbers, every anecdote, every initiative. The leader reads the first screen and skims the rest. Others are too thin: "sales are down, we are working on it." The leader cannot act, so nothing changes.

Your review sits between those extremes. It is short. It covers the area, not each store in turn. It names what is working, what is at risk, and what you recommend. And it treats unit managers as the people who will do the work. You report on their execution; you do not take it over.

The buyer psychology matters here too. A client who asks for an update and hears silence does not conclude that everything is fine. People fill absence with a story, and the story is rarely generous.

They assume something is wrong, or that no one is paying attention. The same is true above you. A senior leader who hears nothing about your area assumes the worst or stops thinking about you at all. Predictable, honest updates build the trust that makes the next request easy to approve.

Reporting Results Without Drowning the Reader

Lead with the area result against target, then the two or three measures that explain it. Use the comparable indicators you learned on Day 2: conversion, lead quality, sales cycle, capacity and customer mix. One line per measure, with direction and the reason. "Conversion up three points; traced to faster quote turnaround in two units" tells a leader more than a page of charts.

Keep context attached. A unit below target because its market is quiet is a different story from a unit below target because its manager is not following up. Say which. Leaders distrust numbers that arrive without interpretation, and clients sense the same gap: a promise with no explanation of the moving parts sounds like hope.

Write results in plain words. If a figure needs a paragraph of caveats, it is the wrong figure for the summary. Put the detail in an appendix and mention it in one line.

Practice example: your area has four units. Area conversion is 22 percent against a target of 25 percent. Three units sit at 24 to 26 percent. One unit sits at 12 percent, and its leads are older, so its cycle is longer. Your summary says: area conversion at 22 against 25; the gap sits almost entirely in one unit; the rest of the area is at target; a recovery plan for that unit is in progress with a named owner and a review date. That is one short paragraph a leader can act on.

Explaining Customer-Facing Risks

Leaders care most about what could hurt clients before the numbers show it. This is where your position earns its keep: you hear what unit managers and their teams hear, and senior leaders do not. Name the risk, who it affects, and what it would cost if it lands.

Then separate it from the fix. State the risk in the review, and state what the unit manager is already doing about it. That keeps the risk visible without pulling execution up to your level. Your recommendation covers what only senior support can unlock: a pricing decision, extra stock, a policy change, a resource.

Follow-up deserves its own line here. More contact is not the same as better follow-up. Ask yourself whether the agreed follow-up is helping clients resolve their questions or just adding touches to a list. A client with an open question wants an answer, not a third call. When you review follow-up with a unit manager, look for resolved questions, not call volume.

Practice example: two units report the same competitor move on delivery times, and clients are asking about it before they buy. Your review names the pattern, shows the orders it touches, and notes that unit managers are calling affected clients with a straight answer. Your recommendation to senior leaders is a decision on matching the delivery offer for the top accounts, with a date you need it by.

> **NOTES**
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> A common mistake is to list every client concern. Pick the risks that would change a senior leader's decision. If a risk changes nothing above you, the unit manager can handle it and report it next time.

Reporting Progress on Commitments

Every review opens with last month's commitments. Take each one: what you said you would do, what happened, and whether it worked. One label per item is enough: done, partial or not started, with the reason. Leaders trust a person whose old promises stay visible.

This is also how you hold unit managers accountable without taking over. Their commitments sit in your review with the same labels. If one is not started, the review says why and what changes. You do not rewrite their plan. You make the gap visible and agree the correction with them before the review.

The psychology is simple. People notice what you follow up on, and they repeat what gets noticed. When managers see that their actions appear in the next review, they take the review seriously. When they see that nothing is ever checked, the plan quietly dies.

Recommending Decisions Senior Leaders Must Make

Each review ends with a short list of decisions you need. Not complaints, not open questions: decisions, each with your recommendation. For every one, state what you recommend, what it unlocks, and by when you need it.

Your recommendation should be specific and testable. "We need more support" is not a decision. "Shift the early morning staffing in Unit B for three weeks, and I will report wait times and lost orders at the next review" is one a leader can say yes or no to.

Keep the ask small in number. A review with seven decisions gets none of them made. Bring the two or three that matter most, and say what you will do yourself if the answer is no.

Practice example: you recommend holding a price level on one product line for the top ten accounts for 30 days, while the two affected unit managers gather lost-order notes. You name the date you need the decision and the date you will report the result.

Keeping Reviews Alive Between Meetings

A review every month or quarter, and silence in between, will not sustain improvement. Improvement lives in the short loop: a written summary after the review, a short update at the agreed interval, and a closing note when a commitment is done or dropped. Your unit managers report to you on their own rhythm; you summarize the area in a few lines.

Make the rhythm predictable. Agree the format and the dates with senior leaders once, then keep them. Predictability is what turns a review from an event into a system, and a system is what sustains results after the attention moves elsewhere.

Apply It in Your Role

As an area manager: own the summary and the plan. Keep each item tied to a measure, an owner and a date. You report on execution; you do not run it.

With your unit managers: agree their commitments and their report dates before the review, not during it. Tell them what appeared in the summary and what senior leaders decided.

With senior leaders: send a short written summary within a day of the review. Three parts: results, risks, decisions needed. Then keep the rhythm.

Across the area: when the same risk shows up in more than one unit, raise it once, at area level, with the evidence from each unit. When it is local, let the manager fix it and report back.

No area role yet? Do the same task with a business you know well (a past employer or a chain you buy from), or with the practice examples in this guide.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you read the model answers.

Exercise 1: Your area is behind target. Two units are fine, one is slightly behind, and one is far behind with older leads and a longer cycle. Write the results paragraph of your area review in four lines or fewer.

Your answer:

Exercise 2: Three units report the same competitor move, and clients are asking about it before they buy. Write the risk line and your recommendation to senior leaders.

Your answer:

Exercise 3: A senior leader asks, "Why should I approve the extra staffing you are asking for?" Write your answer in two sentences, starting with what you will measure.

Your answer:

Key Takeaways

A review exists to get decisions made, not to display activity. Results, risks, decisions needed.

Report the area, not every unit. Use comparable measures and attach context to every number.

Keep unit managers in charge of execution. Your job is to make the area's progress visible and true.

Follow up on commitments every time, yours and theirs. What gets reviewed gets repeated.

Explain follow-up by resolved questions, not contact volume.

Unexplained silence reads as uncertainty, to clients and to senior leaders. Keep a predictable rhythm.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Each is worth 20 points. One answer per question.

1. A senior leader reads your area review and asks, "So what do you want me to do?" Which part of the review failed?

   A. The results section

   B. The decisions-needed list

   C. The appendix

   D. The date of the next review

2. One unit is far below target, but its lead quality is weaker and its sales cycle longer than the rest of the area. What is the right way to present it?

   A. Report the number alone and let leaders interpret it

   B. Leave the unit out to keep the review short

   C. Show the gap together with the context that explains it

   D. Average it into the area figure and say no more

3. During the review, a unit manager's commitment is marked "not started." What do you do?

   A. Take the task over yourself

   B. Make the gap visible, agree the reason and the correction with the manager, and show the new date

   C. Remove it from future reviews

   D. Report it to senior leaders as a people problem

4. Clients keep getting follow-up calls but still have open questions. What does your review recommend?

   A. More touches per client

   B. A new contact schedule

   C. Follow-up that resolves the client's question, measured by resolved questions

   D. Handing those clients to another unit

5. You have four decisions you want from senior leaders this month. What belongs in the review?

   A. All four, with full background on each

   B. None; decisions are not a review topic

   C. The two or three that matter most, each with your recommendation and the date you need it

   D. One, chosen at random to keep the meeting short

Upskill Challenge

Do this on the job within the next 30 days.

No area role yet? Build the review and plan for a business you know, using the practice examples in this guide, and complete it as a written exercise.

Step 1: Produce an area review summary for your next review. Three parts: results against target with context, customer-facing risks, and decisions needed with your recommendation and the date you need each one. Keep it to one page.

Step 2: Produce a 30-day improvement plan. For each item, name the measure, the owner, the support you are requesting, and the review date.

Step 3: Run the review. After it, send the written summary within one day, and give each unit manager their commitments and their report dates.

Step 4: At the next review, open with the commitments from this one. Mark each done, partial or not started, with the reason.

Log your plan here.

Item: ____

Measure: ____

Owner: ____

Support requested: ____

Review date: ____

Decision needed from senior leaders: ____

Date needed by: ____

Your recommendation: ____

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. The principle matters more than the words.

Exercise 1: "Area conversion is 22 percent against a target of 25. Unit A: 26, Unit B: 25, Unit C: 23, Unit D: 12. Unit D's gap sits in older leads and a longer cycle; a recovery plan is running there with its manager as owner, first checkpoint in 14 days. The rest of the area is at or near target."

Why it works: the area figure first, then the one unit that explains the gap, with context and an owner. A leader can act on this in seconds.

Exercise 2: "Risk: three units report the same competitor move on delivery times; clients raise it before they buy, and orders are already affected. Unit managers are calling affected clients with a straight answer. Recommendation: match the competitor's delivery time for our top ten accounts for 30 days. I need the decision by the 12th and will report lost orders and win-backs at the next review."

Why it works: the risk is named with evidence from more than one unit, the execution stays with the managers, and the ask is a specific, dated decision.

Exercise 3: "I will measure wait times at the counter and lost orders in the two affected units, and report both in 30 days. If the numbers do not move, I will recommend we drop the change and put the hours back."

Why it works: it gives the leader a test and a date, and it says what happens if it fails. That is a decision a leader can make with limited risk.

Quiz answers:

1. B. If a leader cannot see what you want decided, the review has not done its job, however good the numbers are.

2. C. A gap without context invites the wrong conclusion; the explanation is what makes the number actionable.

3. B. You hold the manager accountable and make the gap visible without taking execution away from them.

4. C. Volume is not the same as progress; the measure that matters is whether clients' questions get answered.

5. C. A short list of clear recommendations gets decisions made; a long list gets none.

References

Center for Creative Leadership (CCL). SBI: Situation, Behavior, Impact.